

MAGIC HOUR

written by

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FADE IN:

EXT. CAMINO SCHOOL -- OJAI, CALIFORNIA -- MORNING

Oak trees. Mist burning off the hills. An expensive boarding school doing an impression of a ranch: white fences, adobe buildings, a bell that hasn't rung for anything real in eighty years.

A pond. Beside the pond, a new teak BENCH with a fresh rectangle of bare wood where a plaque used to be. Four screw holes.

MILES CALDER, 17, sits on a duffel bag outside the administration building. Sharp-faced, watchful, wearing a school blazer with the crest half picked-off -- threads hanging where the emblem used to be, a project of many bored weeks. He is reading a paperback he is not reading. His eyes are on the bench.

Through the window behind him, half-audible, the DEAN on the phone:

DEAN (O.S.)

(muffled, through glass)

-- we've left two messages with the mother, the letter went out Friday -- no, he's being driven to the bus this morning -- Mrs. Calder travels for work, I understand, but at a certain point --

A GROUNDSKEEPER passes, pushing a cart. He nods at Miles. Miles nods back. They know each other. It's the only warm exchange this campus has left for him.

A Volvo pulls up. MR. HODGES, 50s, history teacher, the kind of man who means well in a way that has never once helped anyone, leans over and pushes open the passenger door.

MR. HODGES

Ojai station. Chariot awaits.

Miles stands, shoulders the duffel. He looks back once -- not at the school. At the bench. Four screw holes.

He gets in the car.

INT. MR. HODGES' VOLVO -- MOVING -- HIGHWAY 33 -- MORNING

Winding road out of the valley. Golden hills, live oaks. Mr. Hodges drives like a man who has read about driving.

MR. HODGES

You know what I keep coming back to? You had a 4.1 as a sophomore.

MILES

(looking out the window)

Yeah, that guy was great.

MR. HODGES

The board would've worked with you. Even after the assembly thing. Even after the grades. If you'd just -- the plaque, Miles. Why the plaque?

Miles watches the hills go by. There's a long guardrail section coming up -- new, brighter metal than the rail around it, maybe forty feet of it, patched into the old rail like a scar.

Miles watches the new section of guardrail approach, pass, and go.

MILES

(quietly)

It had his name spelled wrong.

MR. HODGES

(beat)

What?

MILES

The plaque. "Samuel Ortegas."
With an S. Eleven months, nobody
noticed. It was solid brass,
though. Really nice brass.

Mr. Hodges opens his mouth. Closes it. Drives.

MR. HODGES
(finally, gently, uselessly)
They would have fixed the plaque.

MILES
(still looking out the
window)
Yeah.

EXT. OJAI -- BUS STOP -- MORNING

The Volvo idles. Miles gets out with the duffel. Mr.
Hodges leans across the seat one last time:

MR. HODGES
The 101 connector gets you to the
Amtrak in Ventura, then it's two
hours to Union Station. Your
mother's picking you up downtown?

MILES
(shouldering the bag; the
lie arriving smooth and
pre-assembled)
Yeah. She took the day.

MR. HODGES
Good. That's good.
(beat; he wants a moment;
Miles does not give him one)
Read the Didion I gave you.

MILES
I will.

He won't. The Volvo pulls away. Miles stands alone at the bus stop in the December light. He takes out his phone -- an iPhone 5, cracked screen -- and looks at it.

INSERT -- PHONE: a text thread with "MOM." Her last message, three days ago: "Denver til Sat!! Conference is endless. June w/ Grandma after school. Home Sat night, get a ride from the Hendersons Saturday? Love you." Two hearts.

Miles types: "yeah all good. school stuff til sat." Sends it.

He looks at the sent message for a moment. Then he pockets the phone, and looks down the empty road toward the 101, toward Los Angeles, toward four days that belong to no one.

The bus appears, far off, shimmering in the road heat.

INT. AMTRAK PACIFIC SURFLINER -- MOVING -- DAY

The ocean out the left-side windows, silver and enormous. Miles, forehead against the glass. Across the aisle, a WOMAN, 30s, laptop open to Final Draft, screenplay format unmistakable. She types, deletes, types the same line again.

Miles watches her cursor blink. She catches him.

SCREENWRITER

(not unfriendly)

It's a pilot.

MILES

Sorry.

SCREENWRITER

Don't be. Someone should watch it.

She goes back to typing. Miles goes back to the ocean. Neither smiles. It wasn't a joke. It was information.

EXT. UNION STATION -- LOS ANGELES -- AFTERNOON

The great hall doors. Miles comes out into the light with the duffel, and the film gives us our first real look at it: LOS ANGELES, December 2014, seventy-one degrees, the palms on Alameda backlit and dusty, the sky that particular smoggy gold that photographs like a filter and feels like nothing at all.

Miles stands there. Seventeen, expelled, invisible, four days of runway.

Nobody in the entire city knows where he is. Watch his face discover that this is the best feeling he's had in a year, and that it is also, in the exact same instant, the loneliest.

INT./EXT. UBERX -- TOYOTA CAMRY -- MOVING -- AFTERNOON

A phone mounted on the dash runs the Uber driver app, 2014 edition. Behind the wheel: DEREK, 29, friendly in a caffeinated way, a USC lanyard on the rearview he did not earn at USC.

DEREK

Miles? For Hollywood?

MILES

(getting in back)

Yeah.

DEREK

You can sit up front, man, it's not a taxi. That's the whole thing. It's the future.

Miles stays in the back. Derek pulls out anyway, undiscouraged.

DEREK (CONT'D)

Visiting? You look like you're visiting.

MILES

I live here. Sort of. My mom's in Mar Vista.

DEREK

But you're going to a motel on
Sunset.

MILES

(beat)

Family's remodeling.

DEREK

(nodding at the mirror; not
believing him; not caring;
LA)

Cool, cool.

They merge onto the 101 North. The downtown towers slide
past, then the murals, then the endless specific
everything of the city.

DEREK (CONT'D)

You want the aux? I got Spotify
premium. No ads.

MILES

I'm okay.

DEREK

(driving; then, because no
one in this city can hold it
in past ninety seconds)
I'm actually a writer. Driving's
temporary. Everyone says that, I
know, but I've got a thing that's
basically almost happening --
it's like "Drive" meets "Her,"
it's about a guy who drives for
one of these apps, right, and he
falls in love with the dispatch
algorithm --

MILES

(despite himself)

Does she love him back?

DEREK

(delighted; smacking the wheel)

THAT'S THE MOVIE. That's the question. See -- you get it. Nobody gets it.

(fishing in the console, one hand, handing back a business card)

I do script coverage too. Ten bucks a pop. You know anyone.

Miles takes the card. DEREK KOWALCZYK -- WRITER / COVERAGE / RIDES. A gmail address.

Miles looks at it, then out the window, where the Hollywood sign has just appeared between two buildings, small and white and far, exactly like every photograph of it, which is somehow the surprising part -- that it's really there, being itself, all day.

**EXT. GOLD STAR MOTEL -- SUNSET BOULEVARD, EAST HOLLYWOOD
-- LATE AFTERNOON**

A two-story stucco L around a parking lot. A sign from 1962: GOLD STAR MOTEL -- COLOR TV -- WEEKLY. The Camry pulls away. Miles stands with his duffel under the sign.

INT. GOLD STAR MOTEL -- OFFICE -- CONTINUOUS

Plexiglass. A MANAGER, 60s, watches a Lakers pregame show on a TV wedged next to a fan.

MANAGER

How many nights.

MILES

Four. Maybe five.

MANAGER

ID.

Miles slides his school ID under the plexiglass -- a laminated card with the Camino crest and a photo of a younger, softer him.

MANAGER (CONT'D)

This is a student ID.

MILES

It's all I've got. I can pay
cash. Up front.

The manager looks at him for a long moment. At the duffel.
At the blazer with the picked-off crest. He's seen this
exact kid four hundred times. Every version of what
happens next has already happened here.

MANAGER

(sliding a form under the
glass)

No parties. No guests after ten.
Ice machine's broken since the
earthquake.

MILES

Which earthquake?

MANAGER

(turning back to the
pregame)

Pick one.

INT. GOLD STAR MOTEL -- ROOM 24 -- EVENING

A queen bed with a floral spread. A painting of a harbor
no one has ever visited. The COLOR TV, true to the sign's
promise. Miles sets the duffel down and sits on the end of
the bed.

The room hums. Traffic on Sunset through the window, and a
slice of pink sky between buildings going neon-blue at the
edges.

He unzips the duffel. Clothes. The Didion paperback,
unread. And -- wrapped in a T-shirt, heavy -- the PLAQUE.

Solid brass. "IN MEMORY OF SAMUEL ORTEGAS '15 -- FOREVER
IN OUR HEARTS."

Ortegas. With an S.

Miles sets it on the nightstand, propped against the lamp,
facing the bed. He looks at it the way you look at a
roommate.

MILES

(to the plaque;
conversational; this is
clearly not the first time)

Well. We made it.

He falls back on the bed, arms out, and the neon from the
liquor store across the street comes through the curtain
and moves on the ceiling, red, then blue, then red.

EXT. SUNSET BOULEVARD -- EAST HOLLYWOOD -- NIGHT

Miles walks. The film walks with him -- a long, patient
tracking shot, the first of many: donut shop, botánica,
24-hour laundromat, a man selling roses at a red light to
cars with their windows up.

He passes a BUS STOP where an ACTRESS'S FACE, forty feet
wide, smiles down from a billboard for a network
procedural. Beneath it, on the bench, a MAN sleeps under a
moving blanket, his shopping cart docked beside him like a
car.

Miles stops. Looks at the billboard. Looks at the man.
Nobody else on the street finds this composition
remarkable, and their not-finding-it-remarkable is the
thing Miles can't stop looking at. He takes out his phone.
Frames a photo of the billboard and the bench together.

Doesn't take it.

Puts the phone away and keeps walking.

**INT. ASTRO FAMILY RESTAURANT -- DINER -- SILVER LAKE --
NIGHT**

A googie-architecture diner, orange booths, mostly empty
at 10 PM. Miles in a window booth with a hamburger and the
Didion, still unread, deployed as a shield.

A WAITRESS, 50s, warm, refills his coffee unasked.

WAITRESS
School night?

MILES
I'm homeschooled.

WAITRESS
(deadpan)
Aren't we all.

She moves off. In the next booth, back-to-back with Miles:
two FILM STUDENTS, 20s, one gesturing with a fork.

FILM STUDENT #1
-- because everything's content
now. That's the thing. It's not
movies anymore, it's content.
There's a kid -- I'm serious --
there's a kid who films himself
scaring his roommate, that's the
whole channel, he scares his
roommate, and he has more viewers
than "Boyhood" had in theaters --

FILM STUDENT #2
"Boyhood" doesn't want viewers.
"Boyhood" wants believers.

FILM STUDENT #1
What does that MEAN? You keep
saying stuff like that. It
doesn't mean anything.

FILM STUDENT #2
It means Linklater shot for
twelve years, man. Twelve years.
Nobody scares their roommate for
twelve years.

Miles listens without turning around. His face:
cataloguing. Filing. This is what he does instead of
belonging anywhere -- he collects the city like evidence
for a case he hasn't named yet.

The waitress passes. Miles catches her eye.

MILES

Can I get a slice of the pie?
Whatever kind.

WAITRESS

Whatever kind is cherry.

MILES

Whatever kind is great.

EXT. GOLD STAR MOTEL -- ROOM 24 -- LATER -- NIGHT

Miles on the concrete walkway outside his door, back
against the wall, legs out. Below in the parking lot, a
COUPLE, 40s, argue quietly beside a Nissan with everything
they own in it, the argument long past anger into
logistics.

Miles's phone BUZZES.

INSERT -- PHONE: FaceTime request -- "JUNEBUG."

Miles looks at it. Hesitates -- checks himself in the
black mirror of the screen, actually rehearses a face --
then answers, holding the phone so only wall shows behind
him.

ON SCREEN: JUNE CALDER, 11, gap-toothed, in pajamas, her
face too close to the camera the way kids hold phones.
Behind her, a grandmother's floral wallpaper.

JUNE (ON PHONE)

Why is it dark where you are?

MILES

It's dark where everyone is. It's
night.

JUNE (ON PHONE)

It's not dark in your room at school. You have the lamp with the green thing.

MILES

(a half-second; she is eleven and she is already the only detective in this family)

I'm outside. Looking at stars.

JUNE (ON PHONE)

(suspicious)

You hate outside.

MILES

I'm growing as a person. What do you want, June?

JUNE (ON PHONE)

(instantly down to business)

Okay so Grandma's TV only has cable so I'm editing on the iPad, and I need to know if skeletons should scream when the wave hits or if it's scarier if they're quiet.

MILES

(without hesitation; this is clearly a serious ongoing consultancy)

Quiet. Screaming is for people who think they can still fix it. Skeletons know.

JUNE (ON PHONE)

(nodding slowly, absorbing this like scripture; writing it down somewhere off-screen)

"Skeletons know." Okay. And
you're coming home Saturday?

MILES

(beat)

Yeah.

JUNE (ON PHONE)

Because Mom said Saturday and I
planned the premiere for Sunday.
There's a program. I made a
program.

MILES

I'll be there.

JUNE (ON PHONE)

(holding a piece of paper up
to the camera, too close,
unreadable, trembling with
self-importance)

Assigned seats.

MILES

Wouldn't dream of sitting
anywhere else.

She hangs up first -- she always hangs up first -- and the
screen goes home-screen, and Miles is alone again on the
walkway with his rehearsed face slowly coming off, like
tape.

Below, the couple by the Nissan have stopped arguing. The
man has his forehead on the roof of the car. The woman
rubs his back, once, twice, and stops, and leaves her hand
there.

Miles watches. The neon from the liquor store ticks red,
blue, red.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

**INT. CAFECITO ORGÁNICO ADJACENT COFFEE SHOP -- SILVER LAKE
-- MORNING**

SUPER: "WEDNESDAY"

Reclaimed wood. Edison bulbs. Fourteen laptops, thirteen of them open to screenplays. A BARISTA with a mustache from another century pulls shots with the gravity of a surgeon.

Miles at the counter, reading the menu board, which describes a coffee's tasting notes at greater length than his school described Sam's death.

MILES

Just a coffee. Regular.

BARISTA

Drip's a single-origin Honduran today. Notes of persimmon and brown butter.

MILES

Does it taste like coffee?

BARISTA

(considering the question
honestly)

Toward the end.

Miles pays -- \$4.50, counts it out in cash -- and finds the last table. Around him, a symphony of typing. He opens the Didion, actually reads a page this time. Looks up.

At the next table: a MAN, 30s, headshot-handsome, running lines with himself, mouthing both parts of a scene, doing a small contained version of crying, then checking himself in his phone's front camera, then doing it again. No one looks. This is a library and that is studying.

Beside him, a WOMAN, 20s, holds her phone at arm's length above her avocado toast, adjusting the plate twice before

shooting. She reviews the photo, applies a filter -- that 2014 haze, everything slightly faded like a memory of itself -- types, posts, sets the phone face down, and then does not eat the toast. Just looks out the window.

Miles watches her not eat the toast. She feels it, turns. This is LU -- TALLULAH BECK, 23, Ohio pretty, sharp under the softness, an American Apparel name tag half-visible in her tote.

LU

It's cold anyway. If you're judging.

MILES

I wasn't --

LU

You were cataloguing. That's worse. Judging at least means you care.

Miles closes the Didion.

MILES

Why photograph it if you're not going to eat it?

LU

(matter-of-fact, no shame
anywhere in it)
Because the girl who eats
breakfast here books commercial
work, and I can't afford to be
her and eat her breakfast in the
same month. So I split it. She
eats. I post.

Miles absorbs this like a transmission from another civilization.

MILES

That's the most honest thing
anyone's said to me in four
months.

LU

(gathering her stuff;
clocking him fully now --
the age, the duffel-creased
clothes, the paying-in-cash)
How old are you?

MILES

Nineteen.

LU

(putting on her sunglasses)
No.

MILES

Seventeen.

LU

There he is.
(standing; a decision
arriving on her face, some
mix of boredom and kindness
and wanting an audience)
I have an audition at eleven in
the Valley and my scene partner
canceled. You read flat and dead
-- I can tell just from talking
to you -- which is perfect,
because the casting guy hates
acting. Come read the off-camera
lines and I'll buy you actual
food.

MILES

Why would I do that?

LU

(already walking)
Because you're seventeen with a
duffel bag tan and nowhere to be.
Come on.

**INT. LU'S CAR -- HONDA CIVIC -- MOVING -- THE 101 NORTH --
DAY**

A car that is 30% car, 70% closet. Dry cleaning on the
back hooks, headshots in the footwell -- LU BECK smiling
in four different personalities. The Cahuenga Pass, then
the Valley opening up below, flat and infinite and
shimmering.

LU
(driving; sunglasses;
coaching)
Okay. The scene: I'm a young mom
whose husband is cheating, and
you're reading the husband. It's
for a pilot presentation that
will never air. The line readings
don't matter. What matters is my
face while you talk. Your whole
job is to be boring enough that
they watch my face.

MILES
I can be boring.

LU
Don't oversell it.

Miles flips through the sides -- three pages, marked up in
three colors of ink.

MILES
You've done this scene before.

LU
I've done this scene nine times
this year. Different shows. It's
always the wife finding out.

That's the role for my --
 (she does quote-fingers on
 the wheel)
-- "type." I've found out my
husband was cheating on four
networks. I'm great at it. I find
out better than anyone in this
town.

She says it bright and fast, comedy-fast, but the last sentence lands somewhere real, and she hears it land, and turns up the radio -- a synthy indie thing, all reverb and yearning, the exact sound of this year -- before the silence can attach.

INT. CASTING OFFICE -- NORTH HOLLYWOOD -- WAITING ROOM -- DAY

Folding chairs down a beige hallway. SEVEN WOMEN who all look approximately like Lu, each in the same "young mom" costume -- soft cardigan, minimal makeup -- silently mouthing the same lines. A signup sheet on a clipboard. Somewhere, air conditioning that only makes noise.

Miles and Lu sit against the wall. Miles looks down the row of seven versions of her.

MILES

(low)

Does it bother you? That
everyone's --

LU

(not lowering her voice at
all)

The same? No. See her --

(a tiny nod at one)

-- she'll go too big. Cries every
time. And her -- she'll go too
small because someone once told
her "less is more" and it ruined
her life. I go exactly medium.
Medium is money.

A CASTING ASSISTANT with an iPad appears at the door.

CASTING ASSISTANT
Tallulah Beck?

Lu stands. Instantly -- visibly -- she becomes forty percent softer. Her shoulders round. Her chin drops. Young Mom enters the building and Lu goes somewhere else entirely. It happens in a single step. Miles sees the whole exchange, and it unsettles him more than anything on Sunset did last night.

INT. CASTING OFFICE -- AUDITION ROOM -- CONTINUOUS

A camera on a tripod. A CASTING DIRECTOR, 50s, who has seen everything and retained none of it, eating almonds from a Ziploc. Miles on a stool beside the camera with the sides.

CASTING DIRECTOR
(not looking up)
Whenever.

MILES
(reading; flat and dead, as instructed)
"I don't know what you want me to say. It was one time. It didn't mean anything."

And LU -- Miles's POV, which is the camera's POV -- receives the line. Her face does something in four seconds that Miles could not do with a full page: the news landing, being refused, landing anyway, and then -- the medium part, the money part -- being put away for the sake of a child who is somewhere offstage in the fiction. It's small and complete and genuinely good, and nobody in the room reacts at all.

CASTING DIRECTOR (CONT'D)
(chewing)
Great. Thanks. We'll be in touch through your reps.

LU

(bright; forty percent
softer)

Thank you so much for seeing me.

INT. IN-N-OUT BURGER -- NORTH HOLLYWOOD -- DAY

Red palms on the cups. Lu, back to full voltage,
demolishes a Double-Double with the appetite of a woman
who has skipped the breakfast she photographs. Miles works
on his, watching her.

MILES

You were really good. In there.

LU

(mouth full)

I know.

MILES

Like -- actually good. That's the
part I don't get. If you can do
that, why doesn't --

LU

Because eleven hundred women in
this zip code can do that.
Talent's the cover charge, babe.
It gets you in the door of a room
with no chairs.

(she steals his fries;

gestures at him with one)

Question is what YOU'RE doing.
Seventeen, cash, motel -- I've
seen this movie. It ends at a bus
station or a hospital.

MILES

It's four days. My mom thinks
school ends Saturday. It's not a
runaway thing, it's --

(he searches; and lands,
accidentally, on the truth)

-- it's a gap. I found a gap
where nobody's watching, and I
wanted to see what I'd do in it.

Lu stops chewing. Looks at him -- really looks, for the
first time.

LU

(quieter)

And what do you do in it?

MILES

(beat)

So far I watch other people.

LU

(going back to the fries;
the moment closing like
water)

Yeah. That's this whole town.
Forty square miles of people
watching other people to figure
out how to be one.

(then, deciding something)

There's a party tonight.
Beachwood Canyon. My roommate's
agent's client's house -- don't
ask me to diagram it. Come. You
want to see the terrarium, I'll
show you the terrarium.

EXT. BEACHWOOD CANYON -- HOLLYWOOD HILLS -- NIGHT

A mid-century house cantilevered over the city. Below: LOS
ANGELES AT NIGHT, the full carpet of it, ten million
lights to the curve of the earth. The kind of view that
gets photographed and never gets seen.

INT. HILLS HOUSE -- PARTY -- NIGHT

Sixty people, all between 22 and 35, all lit beautifully
by someone else's success. A DJ plays tasteful electronic.
A pool glows outside like a landing pad.

Miles moves through it behind Lu, holding a Solo cup of something he isn't drinking. The film gives us the party in long takes, conversations drifting past:

A GUY, 26, to a semicircle:

PARTY GUY #1

-- so we don't even call it a web series anymore, we call it "premium digital," and the second we said "premium digital" the money changed --

A WOMAN, 29, to another woman, both nodding:

PARTY WOMAN #1

-- he's blowing up on Vine, which -- okay, six seconds, whatever, laugh -- but brands pay him more for six seconds than my dad made in a month --

Two MEN by the pool:

PARTY GUY #2

It's called Snapchat. It deletes.

PARTY GUY #3

Why would you want it to delete?

PARTY GUY #2

(looking out at the view; a long pause; almost to himself)

Man, some days that's ALL I want.

And everywhere, past every shoulder: eyes flicking to the door whenever it opens. The whole room in a permanent low-grade scan for someone more useful than whoever they're talking to. Miles clocks it -- the over-the-shoulder glance -- happening in every conversation, a party-wide tic, until it stops being funny and becomes the loneliest thing he's ever stood inside.

LU
(materializing; handing him
a water; reading his face
instantly)
You found the thing.

MILES
Nobody's actually here.

LU
Everybody's here. Nobody's
PRESENT. Different problem.
(scanning the room herself
-- and catching herself
doing the over-the-shoulder
scan mid-sentence; owning it
with a grimace)
See? It's in the water.

A HOST-ADJACENT MAN, 30s, blazer over a T-shirt,
materializes at Lu's elbow with the smoothness of a man
who is always mid-approach.

BLAZER MAN
Lu. Who's the young man?

LU
(without missing a beat)
My cousin. Visiting from Ohio.
He's thinking about USC film
school.

BLAZER MAN
(to Miles, instantly,
warmly, horribly)
Love that. LOVE that. What's your
story? Everyone's got a story.
Thirty seconds -- go.

And the party seems to quiet slightly, or maybe just in
Miles's ears. His thirty seconds. The man is actually
waiting, actually looking at him, and this is the only
kind of being-seen this room knows how to do.

MILES

(a beat; then, evenly)

I got expelled from boarding
school for stealing a memorial
plaque with my dead best friend's
name spelled wrong on it, and my
mom doesn't know yet, and I'm
staying at a motel on Sunset
where the ice machine's been
broken since a nonspecific
earthquake.

Silence. Two seconds. Three.

BLAZER MAN

(nodding slowly; then, with
total sincerity)

That's a GREAT logline. Who's
repping you?

He drifts off toward the door, which has just opened. Lu
looks at Miles. Miles looks at Lu.

LU

(quietly; a kind of respect)

You told him the truth.

MILES

It's the only thing here nobody
recognizes.

EXT. HILLS HOUSE -- DECK -- NIGHT

Miles alone at the rail with the water. The city below,
all of it, going forever. Ten million lights and he can
name maybe four of them.

Lu joins him. They stand a moment. The party behind the
glass is a silent film.

LU

(looking at the view)

First year I was here, I drove up
to a spot like this every time I

didn't book something. Which was a lot of driving. I'd look at all that and think: somewhere down there is the version of me that works. I just have to find her and put her on.

(beat)

Four years in -- you want the secret? There's no her. There's just this. You do the face until the face does you.

MILES

(looking at the lights)

That's the thing I'm afraid of.

LU

(turning to him; not unkind; the realest she's been all day)

No. You're afraid it's ALREADY happened. That's why you watch everybody -- you're checking their seams to find your own.

(she finishes her drink)

Fair warning, from the future: everyone's got seams, babe. The only people without them are the ones who stopped taking the costume off.

She heads back inside -- and at the door, reflexively, she checks over her shoulder. Catches herself. Gives Miles a little wave that means: see?

Miles stays at the rail. Below him, Los Angeles glitters like the world's largest unanswered question.

He takes out his phone. Opens the camera. Frames the view -- the shot everyone takes, the shot the internet is made of.

Doesn't take it.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. GOLD STAR MOTEL -- ROOM 24 -- LATE MORNING

SUPER: "THURSDAY"

Miles asleep in his clothes on top of the floral spread. The plaque on the nightstand catches the late sun. His phone BUZZES on the carpet where it fell.

INSERT -- PHONE: "MOM": "Dean's office called Grandma's house?? Trying to reach me. Prob about pickup logistics. Everything ok?"

Miles, one eye open, looks at the message for a long time. Types: "yeah they're disorganized. all handled." Deletes "all handled." Types "don't worry about it." Deletes that too. Sends just: "yeah."

He lies back. The ceiling. The hum.

MILES

(to the plaque; flat)

Don't say anything.

EXT. SUNSET JUNCTION -- SILVER LAKE -- DAY

Miles walks past the reservoir crowd -- joggers, strollers, a man walking two greyhounds in matching sweaters. December sun, seventy-two degrees, everyone in beanies anyway because it's December somewhere.

He stops outside a RECORD STORE: "PERMANENT HIGH FIDELITY -- NEW & USED." A hand-lettered sign in the window: "NO, WE DON'T HAVE THAT. YES, WE HAVE SOMETHING BETTER."

INT. PERMANENT HIGH FIDELITY -- RECORD STORE -- CONTINUOUS

Crates. That smell -- cardboard and dust and forty years of other people's Saturdays. Two customers flip vinyl with the focus of scholars.

Behind the counter, on a stool, reading a paperback with a torn cover: WREN, 19, dark-eyed, self-contained, a film-school thrift-store aesthetic that is somehow the

only outfit in Los Angeles that isn't trying. She doesn't look up when the door chimes. She doesn't look up for anybody.

Miles flips through a crate. Then another. He is aware of her the way you're aware of weather changing. Finally, carrying a record he grabbed mostly as a passport, he approaches the counter.

MILES

How much is --

WREN

(not looking up from the
book)

You don't want that.

MILES

I don't?

WREN

That's a 2011 repress with
brickwalled mastering. It's for
people who want to own the album,
not hear it.

(she turns a page)

Original pressing's in the bin
under it. Four dollars more.
Sounds like a door opening into
1972.

MILES

(beat)

How do you know I wasn't buying
it to own it?

WREN

(finally looking up;
assessing him in one flat
pass)

Because you flipped past forty
records without checking prices

and picked the one closest to the register. You're not buying music. You're buying a conversation.

A silence. Caught. Completely caught. Miles sets the record on the counter.

MILES

Okay. What's the conversation cost?

WREN

(going back to the book; but there's a milligram of a smile now)

Four dollars more. Same as the pressing.

INT. PERMANENT HIGH FIDELITY -- LISTENING STATION -- LATER

A turntable and two mismatched headphones at the back. Miles under one can, Wren -- on break, technically -- under the other, sharing the cord's radius, both facing the wall like it's a movie. The record spins. We hear what they hear: something 1972 and warm, a door opening.

WREN

(eyes on the wall)

So what are you? NYU kid home for break? You've got the "I read" thing going on but your shoes have never worked a day.

MILES

I'm between institutions.

WREN

(turning her head; the phrase earning one raised eyebrow)

Expelled.

MILES

Why does everyone in this city
just SAY the thing --

WREN

Because it's a company town and
the company is watching people.
What'd you do?

And here it comes -- the bit. We've seen the shape of it
now: the shrug loading, the deadpan pre-assembling, "solid
brass, though" waiting in the chamber. Miles opens his
mouth --

WREN (CONT'D)

(back to the wall; mild;
devastating)

And don't do a routine. I watch
four customers an hour do
routines. Just say it or don't.

The bit dies in his throat. Long pause. The record turns.

MILES

(quietly; no shrug anywhere)
My best friend died in March. Car
accident, coming back from a show
in Echo Park -- a show I bailed
on, which is either relevant or
it isn't, I've spent nine months
not deciding.

(beat)

The school put up a bench with a
brass plaque and spelled his name
wrong. And everyone walked past
it all year like it was fine. So
last month I took a screwdriver
and I un-put-it-up. It's on my
nightstand at a motel. I don't
know what I'm doing with it.
That's the actual answer. There's
no routine version.

Wren doesn't say sorry. Doesn't touch his arm. She looks
at the wall a while, with him, both of them inside the

same headphone cord.

WREN

(finally)

What was the show?

MILES

(thrown)

What?

WREN

The show he was coming back from.
What band?

MILES

(a beat; nobody has ever
asked him a single specific
question about it; the
specificity almost undoes
him)

Some four-piece from Highland
Park. They had one EP on
Bandcamp. Sam said they sounded
like --

(and he smiles, wrecked,
remembering)

-- "like The Cure got a day job."
He said that in the last text he
ever sent me.

WREN

(nodding slowly; then,
standing, decision made,
pulling off the headphones)

Okay. I get off at six.

MILES

What happens at six?

WREN

(already walking back to the
counter)
We go find out if they still
play.

EXT. ECHO PARK -- SUNSET BOULEVARD -- EVENING (MAGIC HOUR)

And here the film spends its title. Wren and Miles walk east on Sunset as the light does the thing Los Angeles light does for eleven minutes a day -- gold pouring down the boulevard sideways, palm shadows forty feet long, every stucco wall suddenly a Rothko, and none of it lasts.

They walk and talk in one unbroken take, trading sentences with the ease of people who skipped three stages of knowing each other.

WREN

-- film school's a scam, I take actual film classes at LACC for nothing while the USC kids pay two hundred grand to network with each other's dads --

MILES

So what do you want to make?

WREN

Documentaries nobody asked for. There's a man on my block who's been repainting the same fence for six years. Every day. Same fence. I've got forty hours of him.

MILES

Is it good?

WREN

(considering it honestly)
It's either the best thing ever shot or it's forty hours of a fence. There's no third option.

That's why it's worth doing.

EXT. THE ECHO -- CLUB ENTRANCE -- NIGHT

A small marquee. Tonight's bill: three bands nobody's heard of. Wren scans the names. Shakes her head.

WREN

Not them. But --

(she's on her phone; 2014
detective work: Bandcamp, a
defunct Tumblr, a Facebook
page)

-- their old Facebook says the
singer bartends Thursdays at a
place in Thai Town.

MILES

It's Thursday.

WREN

It's Thursday.

INT. DIVE BAR -- THAI TOWN -- NIGHT

Red vinyl, Christmas lights that never come down, a jukebox glowing in the corner. Behind the bar: the SINGER, 27, tattooed forearms, drying glasses. Wren and Miles at the rail -- Wren's presence somehow neutralizing all questions about Miles's age.

WREN

You used to play in a band.
Four-piece, Highland Park, one
EP.

SINGER

(wary; wiping)
That was a hundred years ago. We
broke up in like April.

MILES

(the date landing on him --
April; one month after)
Why?

SINGER
(shrugging)
Why does anyone. Drummer moved to
Austin. Bassist got a girlfriend
with opinions.
(beat; squinting at them)
Why do two children care?

MILES
(and he doesn't do a
routine; watch him not do
it)
My friend saw you in March. At
the Echo. It was the last thing
he ever did. He texted me from
the show that you sounded like
The Cure got a day job.

The singer stops wiping the glass.

A long moment. The Christmas lights. The jukebox hum.

SINGER
(quietly)
That's the best review we ever
got.

He sets down the glass. Looks at the jukebox. Then he
walks over to it, feeds it quarters from the tip jar, and
punches in numbers from memory.

SINGER (CONT'D)
We put the EP on there. Bribe the
owner with free shifts. Track's
called "Reseda Snow."

The song starts -- reverb-drowned guitar, a drum machine,
a voice like someone singing to you from the next room so
as not to wake anyone. It IS The Cure with a day job. It's
also, played in a mostly empty bar in Thai Town on a
Thursday, the closest thing to a memorial service Sam ever

got.

Miles sits very still and listens to the whole thing. Wren watches Miles listen. The singer leans on the bar and looks at nothing.

Three people, one song, nobody performing anything.

The track ends. The bar hum returns.

MILES

(to the singer; barely)

Thanks.

SINGER

(picking the glass back up;
gruff; kind)

Tell your friend we said hey.

EXT. ECHO PARK -- WREN'S BUILDING -- ROOFTOP -- NIGHT

A four-story walk-up roof: tar paper, two lawn chairs, a dead hibachi, string lights that reach the first chair only. The downtown skyline in the middle distance, lit like an aquarium.

Wren and Miles in the lawn chairs. A shared bag of gas-station peanut M&Ms between them, resting on the arm of her chair like a treaty.

WREN

You know what your problem is?

MILES

People keep telling me tonight,
so -- go, sure, join in.

WREN

You think noticing everything is
the same as being honest. It's
not. It's a hiding place with a
view.

Miles opens his mouth. Closes it. The skyline glitters.

MILES

(finally)

Sam used to just -- be places.
Fully. He'd walk into a room and
like it. No angles. I used to
study him like a foreign film.

(beat)

When he died I think I decided if
I never fully showed up anywhere
again, nothing could ever --

He stops. The sentence knows where it's going and refuses
to arrive. Wren doesn't finish it for him. She eats an
M&M. The city hums.

WREN

(eventually; looking at the
skyline)

My mom died when I was fourteen.
So I'm not going to say the
things people say.

(beat)

I'll just tell you the one true
thing I got out of it: the
missing doesn't shrink. Everybody
waits for it to shrink. It
doesn't. You just -- build a
bigger life around it, so it's
not the only thing in the room.

(she rattles the M&M bag;
practical; unsentimental)

Your life right now is one room
and the missing is wall to wall.
That's the whole diagnosis.
That'll be four dollars.

Miles laughs -- one real laugh, out before he can inspect
it. And in the quiet after, he looks at her -- string
lights, tar paper, the exact face of the only person in
this city who has asked him a specific question -- and the
film lets the moment open: the lean-in available, the
night willing.

Miles doesn't take it. Not out of fear -- out of something
more careful. Wren sees him not take it, and sees why.
It's the most honest thing he's done all week, and they

both know it, and neither says it.

WREN (CONT'D)

(standing; stretching; the
moment folded neatly and put
away)

Get home safe,
between-institutions.

MILES

That's the plan.

It is not the plan. There is no plan.

**INT. FROLIC ROOM -- HOLLYWOOD BOULEVARD -- LATER THAT
NIGHT**

The neon sign outside like a migraine in a good suit.
Inside: a shoebox of a bar, red booths, a mural of dead
celebrities watching from the wall. Miles -- riding the
night, not ready for the motel -- nurses a Coke at the
bar. The BARTENDER left him alone after one ID glance and
a Coke order; the Coke is his cover charge.

Two stools down: GIDEON PRICE, late 40s, in a blazer of
genuine quality gone soft at the cuffs. Handsome the way a
demolished landmark is handsome. Three drinks in, holding
court for no one.

GIDEON

(to the mural, to the
bartender, to the air)

You know what this bar had in
1998? A PAYPHONE. And I was ON
it, nightly. People called ME
back.

He notices Miles. The way lonely performers notice
audiences.

GIDEON (CONT'D)

You know who I am?

MILES

No.

GIDEON

(delighted; wounded; both)
GOOD. Honest child. Everyone else pretends they're not sure. "Were you on that show?" I WAS the show, from '89 to '94. I was on lunchboxes. There is a landfill in Nevada with my face on it, ten thousand times.

MILES

What show?

GIDEON

(waving it away grandly)
Doesn't matter. It's not on the streaming things. I checked. I check monthly. When it's not on the streaming things --
(he taps his temple)
-- it only exists in here. And in the lunchbox landfill.

He slides down a stool. The bartender clocks it -- clocks Miles -- keeps drying glasses, keeps watch. A dive bar's whole immune system in one glance.

GIDEON (CONT'D)

What are you? Actor? You've got a face for it. Sad and symmetrical.

MILES

I'm not anything yet.

GIDEON

(pointing at him; too loud; genuinely moved)
THAT -- is the last honest career description in this town. "Not anything yet." God. Frame that.

(leaning in; the whiskey
doing the talking now, but
underneath it something
true)

Let me tell you what nobody told
me at your age. They will hand
you a self. This town -- it hands
you one, fitted, flattering, and
it feels like being loved. And
you'll wear it, and wear it --

(he looks down at his soft
cuffs)

-- and one day they ask for it
back. And you go looking for
whatever you were before they
fitted you, and kid --

(he smiles; the smile is the
worst thing in the movie so
far)

-- there's nothing back there. I
checked. I check monthly.

Miles sits very still. The mural of dead celebrities
watches.

GIDEON (CONT'D)

(brightening horribly, the
turn too fast)

I've got the residuals coming
next month, and a manager who's
-- she's basically still my
manager -- you drink, you should
come up, I'm around the corner,
I've got the actual PUPPET from
the show, you have to see the
puppet --

MILES

(standing; a twenty on the
bar; the oldest instinct
finally firing)

I gotta go.

GIDEON

(and for one second the
performance drops entirely
-- no charm, no volume, just
a man on a stool in the
middle of his life)

Yeah.

(beat)

Yeah, that's the right answer,
kid. That's the whole test. You
passed.

He turns back to his drink. The bartender gives Miles a
fractional nod: good. Miles pushes out the door.

EXT. HOLLYWOOD BOULEVARD -- NIGHT -- CONTINUOUS

The stars on the sidewalk with names nobody reads. A
COSTUMED CHARACTER -- a superhero, mask under his arm, on
break -- smokes alone against a wall, cape moving in the
night wind off the boulevard.

Miles walks fast, hands jammed in pockets, Gideon's
sentence chasing him: "there's nothing back there."

He walks past a WAX MUSEUM. Past a tour van promising DEAD
CELEBRITY HOMES. Past a group of TOURISTS photographing
the sidewalk, the literal ground, because it has names on
it.

He stops at the corner of Hollywood and Vine because his
body stops. Looks around at all of it -- the lights, the
names, the costumes, the vans.

And for the first time in the film, MILES'S FACE ISN'T
CATALOGUING. It's just seventeen, and lost, and eleven
o'clock at night, sixteen miles from a mother who thinks
he's at school and four hundred yards from a bar where his
own future just bought him a Coke's worth of prophecy.

He takes out his phone. Scrolls to "MOM." Thumb over the
call button.

The screen's clock: 11:47 PM.

He doesn't call. He puts it away. But the film saw him
almost do it, and that's new.

INT. METRO RED LINE -- MOVING -- NIGHT

Fluorescent light. Nearly empty car rocking through the tunnel. Miles in a corner seat. Across the car, a NIGHT-SHIFT WORKER in scrubs sleeps sitting up with her lanyard still on, and a BUSKER with a guitar case rides in silence, off duty, looking at his own reflection in the black window.

Miles looks at his reflection too. The tunnel lights strobe across it.

HOLD.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. GOLD STAR MOTEL -- ROOM 24 -- MORNING

SUPER: "FRIDAY"

Gray light. The first overcast day -- December remembering itself. Miles sits on the edge of the bed, dressed, still. The plaque is in his hands. He turns it over. Turns it back.

"SAMUEL ORTEGAS '15."

He wraps it in the T-shirt. Puts it in his jacket. Not the duffel -- the jacket. Today it travels.

EXT. NORTH HOLLYWOOD STATION -- ORANGE LINE PLATFORM -- MORNING

Miles transfers from the Red Line to the Orange Line busway. The Valley under cloud: flatter, wider, humbler. The billboard faces out here advertise personal injury lawyers instead of shows.

INT./EXT. METRO ORANGE LINE BUS -- MOVING -- MORNING

Miles watches the Valley scroll: body shops, churches in former banks, a hundred small businesses named after somebody's daughter. A pair of ABUELAS across the aisle discuss something hilarious in Spanish. A TEENAGER naps

against the window with his skateboard held to his chest like a rifle at rest.

It's the least glamorous ride of the movie and the film shoots it the most tenderly.

EXT. RESEDA -- RESIDENTIAL STREET -- LATE MORNING

A block of one-story postwar houses, chain-link and rosebushes, old RVs in side yards. Miles walks it slow, checking house numbers -- but his body already knows the way. He's been here a hundred times. Just not since March.

He stops in front of a pale yellow house. A wind chime. A statue of the Virgin in a bathtub shrine, garden kept. On the porch, a rack of drying chilies.

In the driveway: a 2003 CIVIC with a faded parking permit sticker from Camino School on the windshield.

Sam's car. Repaired. Washed. Parked. Kept.

Miles stands at the gate a long time. Long enough that we think he might not. His hand goes to the latch -- and the front door opens first.

LUCIA ORTEGA, 50s, work clothes, reading glasses pushed up in her hair, stands in the doorway. A beat as she processes him -- and then her whole body does something between a flinch and an embrace, both at once, frozen in the door frame.

LUCIA

Milo.

Nobody has called him that in the entire film. His name in this house was always Milo.

MILES

Hi, Mrs. Ortega.

LUCIA

(already turning inside; not
a question)

You eat?

INT. ORTEGA HOUSE -- KITCHEN -- DAY

Small, immaculate, warm. Photos on the refrigerator under magnets: SAM ORTEGA, 17 in the most recent ones -- big grin, a face built for liking rooms -- as a toddler in others, in a First Communion suit in one. A calendar on the wall still turned to MARCH.

The film clocks the calendar and says nothing.

Lucia sets a plate in front of Miles -- reheated pozole, tortillas, the whole liturgy -- and sits across with coffee she doesn't drink.

LUCIA

Your mama said you were away at
the school still. When I saw her
at the Vons in the summer.

MILES

(carefully)

I was. I'm... between semesters.

LUCIA

(looking at him over the
glasses; a mother's radar
pinging once, softly, then
letting it go)

Mm.

He eats. He's genuinely hungry -- days of diner food and gas station M&Ms -- and the eating gives them both somewhere to put their eyes. On the wall: a framed photo of SAM AND MILES, 15, in matching band T-shirts, sunburned, at some outdoor show, Sam mid-laugh, Miles caught for once mid-laugh too.

MILES

(nodding at the driveway;
the question he came with;
almost steady)

You fixed the car.

LUCIA

(stirring the coffee she
isn't drinking)
His tío fixed it. It took him
four months. I told him, Beto,
why, nobody's going to --
(she stops; restarts; the
practiced route around the
hole)
He said a car shouldn't sit
broken. So now it sits fixed.

Beat.

LUCIA (CONT'D)
Sundays I start the engine so the
battery keeps. I sit in it while
it runs. Ten minutes.
(she looks at Miles; no
drama; just the plain report
of a fellow resident of the
country he lives in)
It still smells like him. The
stupid coconut thing on the
mirror. I don't drive it
anywhere. Where would it go?

Miles has stopped eating. Now -- now, in the yellow house,
in front of the only other person for whom the missing is
wall to wall -- he takes the T-shirt bundle from his
jacket and sets it on the table and unwraps it.

The plaque. Brass. "SAMUEL ORTEGAS '15 -- FOREVER IN OUR
HEARTS."

Lucia looks at it a long time. Puts her reading glasses
down from her hair. Reads it properly.

LUCIA (CONT'D)
(quietly)
They spelled it wrong.

MILES
For eleven months. By a pond
nobody sits at. I walked past it
every day waiting for one person

to notice, and nobody --
(his voice going; he presses
on)

-- they had a ceremony, Mrs.
Ortega. Catering. The headmaster
said "Samuel touched us all" and
he called him Samuel, nobody ever
called him Samuel, and then
everyone had lemon bars.

(beat)

So I took it. And they expelled
me. And I've been carrying it
around Los Angeles for four days
like an idiot because I couldn't
figure out what it was FOR, and
then this morning I figured out
it was for you. It should be
somewhere that spells him right.
Even if the plaque doesn't. You
could --

(he runs out of plan exactly
here)

-- I don't know. I don't know
what you do with it. I'm sorry.
Maybe I shouldn't have --

LUCIA

(picking it up; weighing it
in both hands; interrupting
him without raising her
voice)

Milo.

He stops.

LUCIA (CONT'D)

You got thrown out of that school
for this?

MILES

(beat)

Yes, ma'am.

And Lucia Ortega starts to laugh. It ambushes her -- a real laugh, from the floor of herself, tears arriving in it midway and the laugh continuing anyway, both systems running at once, and she puts one hand flat on the table to ride it out.

LUCIA

(through it; wiping her eyes
with her wrist)

He would have LOVED this. You
know that? A brass plaque with
the wrong name and you, walking
around Hollywood with it in your
coat like a -- like a lunatic --
(she catches her breath;
holds the plaque to her
chest, both arms, the laugh
settling into something else
entirely)

-- ay, Milo. You dumb, sweet boy.
You're the only one who did
anything the right size.

Silence in the kitchen. The wind chime outside. Miles
looks at the table.

MILES

(the thing he actually came
to say; nine months in
transit; barely audible)

I was supposed to be in the car.

LUCIA

(gently; she has clearly
always known)

I know.

MILES

I bailed to study for a test. A
TEST. And if I'd gone, maybe he
leaves earlier, or later, or I'm
talking and he's not tired, or --

LUCIA

(putting her hand over his;
stopping the machine
mid-cycle; the authority of
the only person on earth
entitled to rule on this)

Or you're both gone, and I'm
visiting two benches.

(beat)

You want to do the math forever,
mijo, that's the one equation
nobody solves. I tried. His
father tried. You give it years
if you want -- it takes years,
it's happy to take them -- and at
the end it hands you back the
same answer: he's not here, and
you are.

(she squeezes his hand once,
hard)

And you being here is not a
crime. It's just the assignment.
It's the worst assignment. And
you show up for it anyway -- the
way you showed up today.

Miles finally cries. Small, contained, seventeen -- head
down, one hand over his eyes, the other still under hers.
Lucia doesn't gather him up. She just keeps her hand where
it is and looks at the photos on the refrigerator, and
lets the kitchen hold all three of them.

EXT. ORTEGA HOUSE -- DRIVEWAY -- LATER

Lucia and Miles by the Civic. She opens the passenger door
for him. He gets in. She gets in the driver's side. She
turns the key -- the engine catches, settles into an idle.

They sit in the parked car, engine running, going nowhere.
The coconut air freshener sways on the mirror. Miles
breathes in. Closes his eyes.

Through the windshield: the pale yellow house, the bathtub
Virgin, the chilies drying on the porch. Ten minutes,
every Sunday, and today, once, on a Friday, with a
passenger.

Neither of them says anything. The scene runs longer than any studio would let it. That's how we know it's the center of the movie.

EXT. RESEDA -- BUS STOP -- AFTERNOON

Miles waits for the Orange Line, lighter by one plaque. His phone BUZZES. He looks --

INSERT -- PHONE: "JUNEBUG": "why is your location off"

Then immediately: "it's been off for 4 days"

Then: "miles."

Then: "i'm 11 not stupid"

Miles stares at the screen. Types nothing. It buzzes again:

INSERT -- PHONE: "grandma naps at 2. i have \$31 and i know how to use the big bus. tell me where you are or i find you the hard way"

MILES

(out loud, alone, at a bus
stop in Reseda; with total
sincerity)

Oh no.

EXT. SANTA MONICA PIER -- LATE AFTERNOON

Gray ocean, gray sky, the Ferris wheel turning its lights against the overcast like it can fix the weather by itself. Off-season and under-attended: the pier belongs to seagulls, fishermen, and the faithful.

At the rail near the end, holding a churro like a scepter, backpack on both shoulders: JUNE. Beside her, summoned, defeated, holding his own churro he doesn't remember agreeing to buy: MILES.

JUNE

You said the school had a lamp
with a green thing and then you
were outside and then Dean
Whatever called Grandma's
landline TWICE.

(she takes a bite; chews;
prosecutorial)
I put it together in like ten
minutes. Mom's going to put it
together on an airplane with no
wifi and land already knowing.

MILES

I know.

JUNE

Are you expelled?

MILES

Yes.

JUNE

(nodding; filing it; then,
the only question that
matters in her jurisdiction)
Are you okay?

And there it is. Four days, a whole city of people asking
him what he was, what his story was, what his thirty
seconds were -- and an eleven-year-old with churro sugar
on her jacket is the first person to ask that.

MILES

(the truth; simple; new)
Today? Kind of. First time in a
while. Kind of.

JUNE

(accepting the report;
looking at the ocean)
Good.
(beat)
Is it because of Sam?

MILES

(beat)

Everything's a little because of Sam.

JUNE

(matter-of-fact, eleven,
merciless, precious)

I liked him. He talked to me like a person and he did the thing where he pretended my videos were real movies. Wait --

(she turns; outraged by her own memory)

-- he called them FILMS. He said "your films." Nobody says films.

MILES

(looking at the water)

Yeah. He was always saying stuff like that.

The Ferris wheel turns. A fisherman two rails down reels in nothing, checks the hook, casts again -- the whole human condition in one gesture, and June watches it like it's programming.

JUNE

Mom lands tomorrow at four.

MILES

I know.

JUNE

Are you going to be home when she gets there? Actually home?

Because I can cover for you for like an hour, tops. I fold under direct questioning.

MILES

(a small laugh)

You don't fold.

JUNE

I folded about the fish. The fish
died because of me and I folded
in four minutes.

MILES

(beat)

The fish died because of you?

JUNE

(staring straight ahead at
the ocean)

This is exactly what I'm talking
about. I can't live like this.

Miles laughs -- the second real laugh of the film, and
this one has company: June cracks too, and for a second
they're just siblings at a rail, gray ocean, dying light,
two churros.

The laugh settles. June leans her head sideways against
his arm -- too short to reach his shoulder, so it's his
arm, and she has to tilt weird to do it, and does it
anyway.

JUNE (CONT'D)

(quietly; to the ocean)

Don't disappear like that again.

Turn your location on.

(beat)

I don't care where you go. I just
want the dot to be somewhere.

Miles looks down at the top of his sister's head. Then out
at the Pacific -- flat, enormous, indifferent, free -- the
ocean this movie has been walking toward for four days.

He takes out his phone. Settings. Location: ON.

The dot returns to the map of the world.

MILES

There. I'm a dot.

JUNE

(not lifting her head)
You're THE dot.

The Ferris wheel lights deepen as the gray goes to blue.
The film holds the two of them at the rail, small against
the water, for a long, long time.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. GOLD STAR MOTEL -- ROOM 24 -- MORNING

SUPER: "SATURDAY"

The duffel, packed, by the door. The room already
forgetting him: bed made badly but made, harbor painting
straightened for some reason. Miles does a last pass and
finds, on the nightstand where the plaque lived, only the
clean rectangle of dust around where it stood.

He looks at the rectangle. Four days ago an identical
shape was screw holes on a bench.

He wipes the dust away with his sleeve. Some shapes you
don't leave behind for the next guy.

INT. GOLD STAR MOTEL -- OFFICE -- CONTINUOUS

Miles slides the key under the plexiglass. The manager,
same stool, same fan, glances up.

MANAGER

Find what you were looking for?

MILES

(honestly)

I don't know. Some of it.

MANAGER

(back to the TV)

That's the good answer. Kids who
say "yes" scare me.

EXT. PERMANENT HIGH FIDELITY -- RECORD STORE -- MORNING

CLOSED sign. Gate half down. Miles cups his hands to the glass -- dark inside. He takes out Derek's business card -- WRITER / COVERAGE / RIDES -- turns it over, and writes on the back in borrowed pen:

INSERT -- CARD: "The fence movie is the best thing ever shot. There's no third option. -- the conversation you sold for \$4"

He wedges it in the gate. Walks. Stops. Comes back, adds one line:

INSERT -- CARD: "M. Calder. (that's the name for the credits)"

EXT. MAR VISTA -- RESIDENTIAL STREET -- LATE AFTERNOON

A modest street south of Venice Boulevard. Bungalows, jacarandas out of bloom, a mailman finishing his route. Miles walks it with the duffel -- the walk of a man to his own sentencing.

Ahead: his HOUSE. Small, white, a lemon tree. In the driveway, a sedan with a rental company barcode in the window. Mom's home from the airport.

Miles stops at the gate. Through the front window, lit: DIANE CALDER, 40s, still in travel clothes, standing in the living room with a landline cordless in one hand and a piece of mail in the other. The dean's letter. Open.

She isn't pacing. She isn't yelling into the phone. She's just standing there, reading it again, one hand on the back of a chair, and from the gate, through glass, in silence, it's somehow worse than any version he rehearsed.

June's face appears in the window beside her -- spotting Miles at the gate. A frozen beat. Then June holds up one hand: five fingers. Mouths: "I got you five minutes." And vanishes deeper into the house to run whatever interference an 11-year-old runs.

Miles breathes. Opens the gate. The walk to a front door has never been longer in cinema.

INT. CALDER HOUSE -- LIVING ROOM -- CONTINUOUS

The door opens. Diane turns. Mother and son, across a living room, the dean's letter still in her hand.

A silence with years in it.

DIANE

(not loud; which is the
frightening part)

Four days.

MILES

Mom --

DIANE

The school says Tuesday. It is
Saturday. I have been in Denver
assuming my son was doing final
exams, and my son was --

(she looks at the letter;
reads the line that has been
eating her since the
driveway)

-- "whereabouts believed to be
with family."

(looking up)

Whose family, Miles? Because it
wasn't this one.

MILES

I was going to tell you Saturday.
Today. I was always coming home
today --

DIANE

Where did you SLEEP?

MILES

A motel. On Sunset. I had money,
I was careful, I --

DIANE

(the cordless goes down on
the table so she can have
both hands for this)

You're seventeen. Anything -- do
you understand me -- ANYTHING
could have --

(and here the anger's floor
gives way and what's under
it comes through, which is
worse)

I lost --

(she stops herself. Rebuilds
the sentence smaller.)

This family is not big enough to
lose anyone else. Not to
anything. Not even to four days.

The room rings with it. Miles looks at the carpet. When he
finally speaks, it isn't a defense.

MILES

You're right.

DIANE

(thrown; loaded for a fight
that isn't coming)

...What?

MILES

You're right. It was selfish. I
just --

(and now the thing itself,
spoken to his mother for the
first time, no bit, no
shrug, no brass)

Mom, I couldn't come home and sit
in my room and be the expelled
kid whose friend is dead. I've
been that kid in every room since
March. Every adult does the
head-tilt. The voice. And I got
four days where nobody knew to do
the voice, and I took them.

(beat)

I'm not saying it was okay. I'm
saying it was that.

Diane looks at her son. And we watch a mother recalculate
a year of assumptions in real time -- the grades, the
silences, the school's tidy phrases -- against the plain
sentence just handed to her.

DIANE

(finally; quieter)

The school said you vandalized a
memorial.

MILES

The school spelled his name wrong
on it and never noticed. I took
it down and drove it to his
mother's house yesterday. She's
keeping it.

A long silence.

DIANE

(absorbing this; then,
almost against her will)
...They spelled it wrong?

MILES

Eleven months, Mom.

Diane sits down slowly on the arm of the sofa. Looks at
the letter in her hand -- this official, letterheaded
account of her son -- then at the actual boy standing in
the actual doorway.

DIANE

(setting the letter down;
the practical mother
resurfacing because someone
has to)

You're grounded until the sun
burns out. You know that.

MILES

Yeah.

DIANE

Phone location stays on. Forever.
I don't care when you're forty.

MILES

June had the same terms.

DIANE

(rubbing her eyes; a broken
laugh escaping)
Of course she did.
(then, looking at him; the
last item, the real one,
delivered like logistics
because it's too big to
deliver any other way)
Monday we find you a new school.
And a --
(beat)
-- someone to talk to. A
professional. Non-negotiable.
That's the tuition for the four
days.

MILES

(and he means it, which
surprises even him)
Okay.

DIANE

(standing; smoothing her
travel clothes; done --
because if she does one more
second of this she'll come
apart, and dinner won't make
itself)
There's a premiere tomorrow, I'm
told. Assigned seating.

MILES

I've seen the program. It's a strong lineup.

She crosses to the kitchen. Stops as she passes him. And -- not a hug; this family doesn't reload that fast -- she puts one hand on the side of his head, holds it there two seconds, looking at him like she's confirming the object is real. Then she's past him, and pots start.

June's head appears around the hallway corner. She holds up her hand again: five fingers. Then slowly folds four down, leaving one.

JUNE

(mouthing)

You owe me.

EXT. GRIFFITH OBSERVATORY -- LAWN -- SUNDAY -- LATE AFTERNOON (MAGIC HOUR)

SUPER: "SUNDAY"

The great white domes. Tourists thinning as the light goes gold. The whole basin below: downtown to the sea, the city laid out like the answer sheet to a test nobody gets to take twice.

On the lawn, on a blanket: MILES and JUNE. Between them, propped on a backpack: the iPad, playing JUNE'S FILM.

INSERT -- iPad SCREEN: stop-motion. A cardboard city by an aluminum-foil sea. Skeletons -- the plastic Halloween kind -- go about tiny lives: a skeleton waters a plant; a skeleton walks a dog made of erasers. Then the foil sea rises. The wave comes, cardboard buildings tipping frame by frame.

The skeletons don't scream. They stand together at the foil's edge, tiny hands joined with visible loops of thread, and watch it come. Quiet. Because skeletons know.

Then -- the last shot -- the wave passes, and the skeletons are still there. Wet foil everywhere. Still standing. One waters the plant again.

THE END, in June's handwriting, held up on a piece of cardboard by a skeleton.

June watches Miles watch it. The only review she has ever cared about.

MILES

(long pause; genuinely
undone by a Halloween
skeleton watering a plant)
June. It's the best film of the
year.

JUNE

(exhaling; then, all
business)
It's ninety seconds.

MILES

It's the best ninety-second film
of the year, and everything else
is too long.

JUNE

(lying back on the blanket,
hands behind her head,
accepting her laurels)
Sam would've called it a film.

MILES

(looking out at the city)
Sam would've made them screen it
at school and introduced it for
ten minutes.

JUNE

(giggling)
He WOULD.

The light is doing the eleven-minute thing now -- the
whole basin gold, the ocean a white line at the far edge,
every window in Los Angeles briefly on fire, ten million
lives lit at once.

Miles takes out his phone. Opens the camera. Frames the
view -- the city, the light, the shot he has refused all

week.

Then he turns the phone around, stretches his arm -- and takes the picture the OTHER way: him and June, squinting, the city behind them small and out of focus. A terrible photo. Half his head is out of frame. June is mid-blink.

He looks at it.

Keeps it.

JUNE (CONT'D)

(eyes closed, face to the
sun)

Send it to Mom.

MILES

(typing)

Sending it to Mom.

INSERT -- PHONE: the photo, sent to "MOM." Below it he types: "at the observatory with the director. home by 7." A beat. Then the typing bubble from her side. Then just: a heart.

Miles puts the phone away. Lies back next to his sister on the blanket, city noise far below, the dome white above them, the light finishing.

JUNE

(sleepily; apropos of
nothing; eleven)

When I make my real movie, you
can help. You notice stuff. You'd
be good at the noticing job.

MILES

(eyes on the sky; a smile
arriving with no audience to
perform it for -- the first
unwatched smile of the film)

Yeah. I'm thinking about going
into noticing.

The gold goes. The blue comes. The city lights rise to meet the dark the way they do every single night, whether

anyone earns it or not.

The two of them stay on the blanket, small on the lawn,
the observatory keeping watch behind them.

We pull back -- the lawn, the domes, the hills, the whole
impossible city --

And hold.

FADE OUT.

THE END